

Eurystheus had been thwarted every time. For the final task, he sent Heracles to do the impossible—to go to the underworld itself and steal Hades’ dog, Cerberus. This was no ordinary hound. Cerberus had three heads and a scaly dragon’s tail.

Rather than anger Hades, Heracles decided to speak to him directly. He went to Hades’ palace and asked, “May I borrow your dog, Cerberus, if I swear to return him afterward?” Hades was unsure, but his wife, Persephone, felt sympathy for the hero and persuaded Hades to compromise.

“You may take my dog for a while,” Hades told Heracles, “but only if you can catch him without using your weapons.”

*When Heracles approached Cerberus, all three of the dog’s heads snarled.*

Heracles wrestled Cerberus with all his might. Even when the dog bit him, he did not let go. Eventually, the dog lost consciousness and Heracles carried him away. Eurystheus was astonished when he saw the monstrous hound, and when Cerberus stirred, the king ran away. Heracles had completed all 12 labors! Just as the Pythia had said, Heracles became immortal and went to join the gods on Mount Olympus.

